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Preparing to Write: An Interview with Sarah Cho

In Room 1301 at the UTPB campus, I had an insightful talk with Dr. Sarah Cho, a professor and the chair of Communication at the University of Texas Permian Basin. As she shared her writing experiences in the academic realm, I realized why writing is so meaningful to her, not only as a researcher and teacher but as a person. Before she ever wrote a research paper, Cho spent ten years as a book editor in South Korea, and it took her about another decade of graduate school to master academic writing. Throughout the conversation, I kept noticing one key theme that united all of her writing experiences: the importance of preparation. By talking about the failures and successes in her writing career, Cho demonstrated that the most successful writers put as much effort into preparing to write as into the writing itself. The same applies to me, a humble student who is trying to become a better writer with each paper.

Cho's path to academic writing was itself a long preparation. As a book editor, she came to see reading and writing as forms of communication, a way of delivering and receiving messages, and that idea led her to study communication. She went on to attend four different graduate schools, where professors taught her how to write a research paper, a skill she admitted took her ten years to learn. Part of the difficulty is the form itself. A research paper has many sections, from the abstract and introduction to the method, analysis, discussion, conclusion, and references, and each one reflects years of research rather than a simple summary. Looking back, Cho said the advice she would have wanted as a beginner was a clear, straightforward template

that showed her where each part belonged. Today, she gives her own students templates so that they only have to "fill in the blanks." In her view, a first draft does not have to be perfect, but a template helps a writer begin, and beginning is the first step of preparation.

Cho's everyday writing process shows the same habit. Before she writes full paragraphs, she builds a structure with bullet points: an introduction with its main points and a body with its own numbered sections. She starts with the main ideas, and only when the overall structure looks right does she fill in the small details and turn the outline into a longer paper. Sometimes she realizes at the outline stage that an idea will not work, so she goes back and starts the structure again. Because she has only written an outline, she does not waste much time. For Cho, preparation is a way of failing early and cheaply. Even her strategy for writer's block is a kind of preparation. Instead of forcing herself to write, she looks for a new experience, such as visiting a place she has never been, trying a new restaurant, or tasting a food she has never eaten. She explained that she needs "full body processing" of new information before the words come back.

The importance of preparation became even clearer when I asked Cho about a piece of writing that did not turn out the way she hoped. She described a paper based on interviews with North Koreans, a rare case study. However, she started the project very early in graduate school, before she had enough knowledge to design her interview questions well. By the time she understood what the paper needed, she could not go back and change the interviews she had already conducted. The paper took six years to publish, much longer than she expected, and it did not appear in the kind of journal she had hoped for. Cho said the lesson she took from this experience is that designing and preparing the interviews is just as important as the writing itself, and that a writer should begin writing only when all of the resources are fully prepared.

In contrast, her proudest work shows what patient preparation can produce. Cho described her research articles as being "like my kids," because each one takes years to complete. Her most recent paper took ten years. It studies Korean immigrants who run small stores in the United States and whose English is "limited, like me," as she put it, as they try to build relationships with their customers. After a decade of work, the paper is finally ready to be published. Hearing her compare herself to the people in her study showed me that her research is personal as well as academic.

Cho also treats feedback as part of preparation. Because her friends and her husband are often too busy to read her drafts quickly, she uses a paid version of an AI tool to review her work. She is careful about how she uses it: she asks it for comments and suggestions about what she has missed, what she could develop in more depth, and her English, but she never asks it to revise the paper for her. She also presents her research at academic conferences, where audiences respond with comments and sometimes with criticism. Her next presentation will be in Atlanta, Georgia, in March 2027. Comments are usually helpful, she said, but criticism can make a writer feel small, so the key is not to take it personally. In this sense, feedback is another stage of preparation, because it strengthens a paper before it reaches its final readers.

Cho's career also shows how a writer's preparation must change with the audience. As a book editor, her writing was audience-centered: she thought about what readers would enjoy and wrote sentences that were easy to follow. Academic writing changed everything. Her style became more author-centered and intellectual, aimed at a small group of scholars who share her interests. Adapting to that new audience required her to learn a new set of expectations almost from the beginning.

As our conversation came to an end, Cho gave me some valuable insight that helped me see my own writing process in a new light. When I asked what resource she would recommend, she named Google Scholar and repeated the idea of "standing on the shoulders of giants." She explained that countless scholars and professors have already written about almost every topic, and that a writer only has to climb onto their shoulders to understand the world. In other words, a writer does not have to reinvent the wheel but can build on the existing ideas of others. This metaphor connects everything I learned from her experiences. Her outlines, her templates, her careful interview design, her use of feedback, and her reading of other scholars all show that writing is a long process that requires much preparation before the actual writing begins. Her final piece of advice was simple: writing is like speaking, so practice is the key. Reading is important, but it is not the same as writing, and short texts like social media posts are very different from long, demanding pieces.

Cho's experiences serve as a great reminder that writing is a process that cannot be separated from preparation. Whether it is building an outline, designing interview questions, asking for feedback, or reading the existing research on a topic, preparation makes writing easier and more organized. Her approach of standing on the shoulders of giants applies to all kinds of writing, including the writing of students. As a student who also writes in her second language, I found it encouraging that Cho, who once had to learn academic writing from the beginning, now teaches it to others. By realizing that preparation and practice matter as much as the writing itself, I have come to understand that I can become a better writer than I am now.

Works Cited

Cho, Sarah. Personal interview. 9 Oct. 2026.